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# A Government in ICU

The Congress-led United Progressive Alliance probably lost Verdict 2014 on 1 June 2011, almost three years before judgement day. It was a searingly hot day in June when four Union ministers of the UPA government rushed to Delhi airport to receive yoga guru Baba Ramdev and urge him to call off his proposed fast against corruption and black money. The sight of the government prostrating itself before the controversial saffron-robed self-styled ‘guru’ as though he was a distinguished head of state said it all—the UPA government had lost its nerve and, perhaps, its self-esteem too.

The ministerial delegation to the airport was led by then finance minister Pranab Mukherjee and comprised telecom minister Kapil Sibal, parliamentary affairs minister Pawan Kumar Bansal and tourism minister Subodh Kant Sahay. Months later, I asked Mukherjee about the airport visit. Over several cups of lemon tea, Mukherjee admitted, ‘It was a blunder, a big blunder. We should have never done it,’ and, pointing to a photograph of Indira Gandhi on the wall behind him, added, ‘We needed leaders like her to put these babas in their place.’

The Hardwar-based saffron-clad Ramdev was born Ramakrishna Yadav in a Haryana village. His yoga skills transformed him from a village boy to a highly successful businessman, running a chain of yoga training institutes across north India. He had even diversified into manufacturing herbal products. His critics accused him of being a land-grabber and selling fake herbal medicines, but his supporters saw him as a soldier of God (one of them had ‘gifted’ him an island near Scotland). He definitely was politically ambitious. ‘I want to change India, Rajdeepji,’ he told me, looking at me with his piercing eyes that seemed to hide many mysteries. Latching onto